optimistic when the first waves of European Jews began immigrating to Palestine. “We helped you,” he said, brandishing a copy of a letter from a man named Yossi Nachman, a resident of the Galilee in the *yishuv*, the pre-state Jewish community, who thanked the Maronites for their help. “And we continue to help you,” he added, explaining that many Maronites serve in the army. Khalloul himself is a reserve captain in the paratroopers.

“We live better than in all the surrounding countries,” Khalloul told me later, over a chicken lunch; he pointedly refused to speak in Arabic, offering to do the interview in Hebrew, Aramaic, or English. “Where I’m standing now, it’s only two hours from Damascus, from Syria. Can you imagine if these guys could enter this land? What would happen to us? So today I evaluate the situation, and I value being under Israeli Jewish control.”

In the earliest days of the Israeli state, Arabs were viewed as a potential fifth column. They were allowed to vote and run for office, and Arab lawmakers have served in every Knesset. But they lived for decades under martial law, subject to nightly curfews and periodic expulsion from their homes and villages. The military regulations were not fully lifted until 1966.

Israel’s first conscription law, drafted in 1949, was neutral on gender, religion and ethnicity. It required everyone to serve in the army, except for mothers and pregnant women. But it allowed the defense minister to make exemptions, a prerogative that David Ben-Gurion used to excuse the Arab minority from military service.

His successor, Pinhas Lavon, canceled that exemption in 1954 and ordered the army to begin drafting Arabs. Lavon’s career would be short-lived, though. He resigned in February 1955 after it was revealed that he had recruited Egyptian Jews to bomb British- and American-owned targets in Cairo and Alexandria. The disastrous plot, dubbed the “Lavon Affair”, was rooted in the fear that Egypt would nationalize the Suez Canal. Lavon hoped that the bombings would damage Britain’s relationship with the Egyptian government and convince London to maintain troops in the canal zone.

Ben-Gurion returned to the defense ministry after Lavon’s departure, and quickly halted the draft program. Instead he struck a deal in 1956 with the leaders of the small Druze community, a secretive sect that practices a syncretic offshoot of Islam, who agreed to send their young men to the army. The decision was deeply controversial. Indeed, a 1956 report from the